member of the national squad. It wasn't a huge amount – something like R12 000 or R13 000 a month, basic – but with match fees, win bonuses and a few sponsorships, I could afford some of the things I really wanted.

I remember saying to my first agent, Trevor Torrington, 'Listen, I've got a national contract now. Surely I can afford a Volkswagen Golf VR6?' My friend and teammate Paul Adams had just bought an Alfa, and I wanted a cool set of wheels too. I wasn't satisfied with average stuff any more. My tastes were expanding … and so was my bank account. Unfortunately, though, my tastes often expanded way ahead of my bank account.

From 2000 onwards I started playing regularly for the Proteas, and that meant my bank account started to accumulate nicely. When you're in the starting XI, the match fee and a win bonus can add up to about R200 000 a month – though it does vary. That's just the Proteas money, though. Playing county cricket and, more recently, the Indian Premier League (IPL), increases your income significantly.

I've always been quite a big spender. I mean, we're not talking huge amounts of money, but when I started playing for South Africa, I started spending quite a lot of cash on clothing. I'd met these guys who worked at a very upmarket men's clothing shop at the V&A Waterfront in Cape Town, and I just kind of got convinced to buy all this expensive clothing – a lot of exclusive brands like Pal Zileri, an Italian label.

I was suckered, I guess. I've always liked suits, these guys figured it out, and I reckon they saw a good thing coming. I'd always wanted to wear whatever the latest fashion was, and those guys stocked it.

Ja, I used to spend quite a lot of money. I wouldn't think twice about paying R2 000 for a belt and double that for a pair of shoes. I'd go a couple of months without spending a cent and then blow 20K in one shot.

The most expensive item of clothing I ever bought was my Dolce&Gabbana suede jacket – more like a blazer, actually – but a stunning piece of clothing. It set me back about 16K. It's blue. But stunning, believe me. About a year later I was shopping in the UK and happened to come across a pair of D&G shoes in exactly the same colour as the jacket. Obviously, I bought them. Actually, I bought three pairs – in blue, red and black. The best pairs of shoes I've ever bought. I hardly wear them, though.

I still love my clothes – last year I was one of *GQ* magazine's Best Dressed Men in Sport – but I've cut down a *lot* on my spending. I don't see